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particulière, dont s'est servi Armonio.

Nous signalons, enfin, avec plaisir, que M. Ludwig
présente dans sa préface un vibrant plaidoyer en faveur de l'édition systématique et
scientifique des textes latins de la Renaissance.
R. Desmed.
Opera omnia Desidera Er asmi RoterodamU recognita et adnotatione critica instructa
notisque illustrata. Ordinis quinti tomus primus (V-l), Amsterdam et Oxford, NorthHolland Publishing Company, 1977, viii-410 p., 26,1 cmx 17,5, 7 pl.
Ce volume contient cinq ouvrages de caractère spirituel ou catéchétique, dont quatre
exécutés sur commande.
De contemptu mundi (éd. S. Dresden) : première œuvre d'Érasme, rédigée sans doute
avant 1490, mais publiée seulement à Louvain en 1521. L'introduction conclut, compte
tenu des conventions littéraires, que, dans sa teneur générale, cette epistola

sur la vie
monastique mérite d'être prise au
sérieux. Elle s'inscrit dans une
tradition qui remonte au
Moyen Age. Le chapitre XII, rédigé après
coup, n'est pas en contradiction absolue
avec le
corps de l'ouvrage.
Virginis Matris apud Lauretum cultae
Liturgia (éd. L. E. Halkin) : la
princeps, Bàie,
1 523, ne donnait que le texte même de
la messe : on suit ici la seconde
édition, accrue d'un
sermon et de l'approbation de
l'archevêque de Besançon. L'introduction
souligne le
caractère complexe de la piété d'Érasme.
Modus orandi Deum (éd. J. N. Bakhuizen
Van Den Brink) : texte de la princeps,
Bàie,
1523, où sont insérés les importants
compléments de 1525. L'introduction
analyse les
concepts théologiques et retrace
latradition littéraire dugenre. Une
heureuse initiative :

l'éditeur, pour cette œuvre comme pour
la suivante, donne la description
bibliographique
complète des éditions utilisées.
Explanatio Symboli Apostolorum (éd. J.
N. Bakhuizen Van Den Brink) : éd.
princeps,
Bále, 1 533. Dès la fin du Moyen Age,
l'instruction de la foi a cédé sa place
prépondérante
à l'enseignement moral. Par ce traité
didactique très complet, Érasme renoue
avec une
longue tradition. Quant à l'authenticité
philologique des différents Credo, son
opinion, qui
est celle de son temps, reste flottante.
De praeparatione ad mortem (éd. A. Van
Heck) :la princeps, Bàie, 1 534, est
comparée
au manuscrit autographe, qui représente
un état antérieur du texte.
L'introduction retrace
la diffusion du livre et dresse un
inventaireaisonné des variantes. Une
constatation
intéressante : làoù les citations

bibliques d'Érasme s'écartent de la Vulgate, c'est par
réminiscence duchant liturgique.
Roland Crahay.
Henry Cornelius Agrippa, Of the Vanitie and Uncertaintie of Artes and Sciences , ed. by Catherine M. Dunn, Northridge, California State University, 1974, xxxv-453 p., 1 port.
Henri Corneille Agrippa de Nettesheim connut une vie agitée tant sur le plan spirituel
que sur le plan matériel ; son intérêt pour les sciences occultes et ses sympathies pour la
Réforme ne contribuèrent pas à lui assurer la tranquillité, comme le montre M"* Dunn
dans une courte introduction. Agrippa écrivit son De incertitudine et vanitate scientiarum
et artium, l'ouvrage le plus représentatif de sa pensée, en 1 526, à un moment de profond
découragement, de pessimisme et de scepticisme envers toutes les connaissances. Il croyait

trouver dans la religion, ou plutôt dans une sorte de fidéisme, la réponse à ses problèmes intellectuels et moraux, tout en dénonçant les

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KNOWLEDGE AND FAITH IN THE THOUGHT OF CORNELIUS AGRIPPA

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KNOWLEDGE AND FAITH IN THE THOUGHT

OF CORNELIUS AGRIPPA

The enigmatic figure of Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486-1535) has been subjected to various interpretations since the early 16th Century. Even his contemporaries were never quite sure what to do with him. Lauded as a great scholar and leading man of letters on the one hand, he was condemned as a wicked practitioner of the black arts and collaborator with devils on the other 1. Men of later generations were equally divided. The great skeptical works of Sir Philipp Sidney and of Montaigne were consciously modeled after Agrippa's volume, On the Uncertainty and Vanity of the Arts and Sciences , while Giordano Bruno and Thomas Vaughan took his three books of occult philosophy as a model. For Marlowe and, to a lesser extent, for Goethe, Cornelius Agrippa was the original Faust 2.

The difficulty is that there has always

seemed to be two Agrippas - the one who wrote De Occulta Philosophia , proclaiming that the world was tied together with pervasive mystic bonds and that the intelligence of man was capable of utilizing the occult qualities of the universe for his own advantage, and the other Agrippa, the author of De Incertitudine et Vanitate Scientiarum9 Declamatio Invectiva , et Excellentia Verbi Dei , a violent declamation against all of man's learning and against the possibility of his reaching understanding

1 According to his first biographer, at one time Agrippa was offered employment by three different courts, including that of the Emperor Charles V, into whose court he entered in1530 as Imperial Historiographer. See Henry Morely, The Life of Henry Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim , Doctor and Knight , Commonly Known as a Magician (London : Chapman and Hall, 1856), Vol. 2, p. 259. On the other hand, Melanchthon regarded him as being on

intimate terms with the devil. On this point, see the quotation in Philip Mason Palmer and Robert Pattison More, The Sources of the Faust Tradition (New York : Oxford University Press, 1936), p. 102. 2 For the similarity of Sidney's «Apology for Poetrie » and Agrippa's de Vanitate ,
see A. C. Hamilton, « Sidney and Agrippa », Review of English Studies , ns, 7 : 151-7, (April, 1956). Pierre Villey in his Les Sources et révolution des Essais de Montaigne (Paris, 1933), II, 166-170, notes the close relationship between de Vanitate and parts of Montaigne's « Apology for Raymond Sebond ».For Giordano Bruno, see Ernest Cassier, Das Erkenntnisproblem in der Philosophie und Wissenschaft in Neueren Zeit (Berlin, 1906-7), I, p. 344-5. For Thomas and Henry Vaughan, see A. C. Judson, « Cornelius Agrippa and Henry Vaughan », Modem Language Notes , 41 : 178-181 (March, 1926). In Scene I, lines 96-116, Marlowe's Faust specifically takes Agrippa as his ideal. For the relationship of Agrippa to Goethe's

Faust, see Anton Reichl, « Agrippa and Gœthe's Faust,» Euphorion , IV, 1897, p. 287-301.

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through reason r. On the surface at least, the two Agrippas do seem incompatible, and until very recently, historians have followed the pattern of choosing one of them and discounting the other as a fraud, or at least, the victim of a temporary intellectual aberration. A few, following Marlowe, have looked upon him as a Faustian character who, at a certain point, renounces scholarly allegiance to human sciences and turns to the black arts 2. In 1957, an ingenious attempt was made by Charles G. Nauert

to unite the two strands in the character of Agrippa, by interpreting him as a paradigm of the dialectical movement of Western European thought which Hiram Haydn saw as characterizing the period 3.

This paper arose out of the conviction that an insistence upon viewing Agrippa either in terms of intellectual development or discounting one side of his thought necessitates an entirely false final evaluation of the man, and, what is more serious, a misunderstanding of his real significance in the history of thought. A comparison

- implied or otherwise - of Agrippa with Faust does have a certain

seductive appeal, and interpreting him as a paradigm of the dialectical movement of Haydn's " Counter-Renaissance " thesis is even more tempting. But either effort precludes a real understanding of the relationship between magic, skepticism,

and modern science. A
brief chronological sketch of the major
events in Agrippa's life will
make clear the difficulty of a
developmental analysis.
Agrippa was born in 1486 at Cologne and
sometime before 1506
had studied jurisprudence and medicine
at Cologne and Paris,
although he took no degree. He spent the
next two years in Spain, in
part as a military adventurer and in
part as a student in the company
1 The edition I have used is Agrippae :
Opera in Duos Tomos Concinne , Lugduni,
Per Beringos Fratres, n.d. (fictitious
imprint: probably Strasburg in the early
17th
Century). (All translations areby me.) 2
Lynn Thorndyke, A History of Magic and
Experimental Science (New York :
Columbia University Press, 1941) ; V,
Chapter 8,sees Agrippa as primarily a
practitioner of the black arts ; August
Prost, in Corneille Agrippa: sa vie et
ses œuvres (Paris,
1881, 1882) interprets him as a skeptic

and a charlatan. The Faust interpretation can be found in various places, most prominently in the article referred to above by Reichl, but also in Agnes Bartscherer, Paracelsus , Paracelsisten und Gœthes Faust , (Dortmund, 1911) especially p. 23-25, and in Harold Jantz, Gœthe's Faust as a Renaissance Man (Princeton : Princeton University, 1951), passim. For a good summary of interpretations of Agrippa, see Charles G. Nauert, "Magic and Skepticism in Agrippa's Thought", Journal of the History of Ideas , 18 : 161 fï., (April, 1957). Nauert also deals with the question of whether Agrippa was merely "declaiming " in his De Vanitate and demonstrates that he did not, in his Apologia , retract any of the views, as distinghished from some of the obviously fantastic stories, whiche had expressed in the earlier work.

3 Nauert, "Magic and Skepticism in Agrippa's Thought." Nauerťs debt to

Haydn
is not, of course, without
acknowledgement. Nauert summarizes the
Haydn thesis
on pp. 165-6 in the following manner :
"In opposition to the orderly world view
which
the Thomists and the humanists shared,
there arose ageneral skepticism
concerning the power of the human mind
to gain truth. This skepticism in turn
produced two
results, sometimes at odds but often
found in the same person : unsystematic
empiricism, which granted truth only to
sensory knowledge, and occultism, which
appealed rather
to gnostic traditions ofrevealed truth,
especially the Hermetic and the
cabalistic.
Finally, these two tendencies,
especially the empirical, contributed in
some measure to
the birth of modern scientific
methodology, which restored faith in the
power of the
human mind, but on a different level

from that of medieval rationalism." For Haydn's
thesis, see The Counter-Renaissance , New York, 1951.
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of a group of theosophists. In 1509, he lectured at the University of Dole on Reuchlin's Hebraic studies, with such success that, according to his own account, he was granted a degree of Doctor of Divinity by the University. In the same year, he wrote his treatise on the nobility and pre-eminence of women, a logical argument combined with tortuous Biblical exegesis. In the following year, he wrote the first draft of his three books on occult philosophy. He was then sent

on a diplomatic mission by the Emperor
Maximilian to England,
where he was a guest of Dean Colet. By
the end of 1510, he was in
Italy, where he was knighted for bravery
at the battle of Ravenna.
In 1515 - again according to his own
account - he was admitted as
Doctor of Medicine and of Jurisprudence
for his lectures at Pavia on
Hermetic philosophy and Marcilio
Ficino's commentary on the
Pimander. In the next few years, Agrippa
was town advocate and
orator at Metz, where he also practiced
alchemy on the side ; municipal
physician at Fribourg, and physician to
Louise of Savoy. He was
forced to leave the service of Louise in
1526 for having first refused
to cast a horoscope for her on the
grounds that it was " superstition,
unworthy of a Christian ", and then,
upon being pressured, casting
a horoscope which anticipated the
success of the Duke of Bourbon.
It was in this year that he wrote his

skeptical Treatise, de Vantiate.
The treatise was not printed until 1530,
the same year in which he
addressed a paper advocating empiricism
in medicine to the Grand
Council of the Netherlands. This wras
intended as a defense of Jean
Thibault, who had practiced with him at
Antwerp during the plague.
The next year he began preparing his de
Occulta Philosophia for
publication, acknowledging in his
dedication to Hermann von Weid
that despite the inclusion of much that
was probably in error, the
work contained "
many useful and necessary things ". In
1533, he
published his commentary on the Lullian
system. He spent his last
two years wandering, and died under
obscure circumstances at
Grenoble in 1535. His only publications
in this final period of his life
were a series of letters exposing the
injustices to him of Louise of
Savoy - letters for which he spent some

months in prison r.
From this chronology, it is evident that
Agrippa, to say the least,
was hardly a Faust figure. True, both
Faust and Agrippa had grasped
the whole range of human learning and
both had found it wanting.
But it is not accurate to say that
Agrippa turned to magic - there is
no dramatic turning point in his life,
nor is there a series of minor
turning points which can fit into
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ESTHER GILMAN RICHEY
“To Undoe the Booke”:
Cornelius Agrippa, Aemilia Lanyer
and the Subversion of Pauline Authority

omen of the Renaissance were enjoined to silence and submission by a voice that echoed with renewed force throughout the seventeenth century, a voice privileged in the sermons, tracts, and arguments of that time-the unequivocal pronouncement of the Apostle Paul:' "Let the woman learne in silence with all subjection. I permit not a woman to teache, nether to usurpe autoritie over the man, but to be in silence. For Adam was first formed, then Eve. And Adam was not deceived, but the woman was deceived & was in the transgression" (I Tim. 2.11-14).~ If women were to find a place for themselves as speakers and writers, they must first call into question Paul's interpretation of Genesis; they must first overturn his assessment of Eve.3 Among those who took up this task, no woman did so with more

I. Suzanne W. Hull discusses the influence of Pauline authority on women in Chaste, Silent and Obedient (San Marino, 1982), pp. 106-26, and a wide range of criticism

offers the same
assessment. See, e.g., Margaret Ezell,
The Patriarch's Wqe: Literary Evidence
and the History oJthe
Family (Chapel Hill, 1987). p. 16;
Silent Butfor the Word, ed. Margaret
Patterson Hannay (Kent,
OH, 1985); Constance Jordan, Renaissance
Feminism (Ithaca, 1990). pp. 22-33; The
Paradise of
Women ed. Betty Travitsky (London, 198
I), p. 5; Elaine Hobby, Virtue
OfNecessity (Ann Arbor,
19891,pp. 5-11.
2. The Geneva Bible: a Facsimile ofthe
1560 edition (Madison, 1969).
3. For an analysis of Paul's influence
on Renaissance texts in general, see
John S. Coolidge,
The Pauline Renaissance in England:
Puritanism and the Bible (Oxford, 1970).
Coolidge argues that
Pauline authority led the Puritans to
"feel the old modes ofpresentation as a
form ofbondage"
(p. xiii). As I will demonstrate here, a
number ofwriters felt that Paul had not

gone far enough.
Because Paul placed women under the
“law,” he put them in the very “bondage”
kom which
Christ came to liberate them. When it
came to defining woman’s role on the
basis of the biblical
record, men and women of the Renaissance
found themselves in a double bind it was
the
“Word” that liberated women to speak and
to write if they took seriously the
statement of the
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art, authority, or skill than Aemilia
Lanyer in Salve Deus RexJudaeonrm
(161 I). Yet despite the recent surge in
scholarly criticism of Lanyer’s
we have not yet analyzed the revision of
Paul that informs Lanyer’s passion
narrative, nor have we identified the
subversive hermeneutic method that
provides Lanyer with the impetus for

this revision.
What we have identified are the
questions that puzzle us. Barbara K.
Lewalski, for example, closes each of
her articles with an awareness of
how much we do not know, particularly
about Lanyer's feminism:
"How should we account for the feminist
thrust of [Lanyer's] volume,
which rewrites patriarchy by revising
the fundamental Christian myths:
Eden, the Passion of Christ, the
Communion of Saints, with women at
prophet Joel, "I wdl pour out my Spirit
upon all flesh; and your sons and your
daughters shall
prophesy" (Joel 2.28). The Word also
silenced them in the definitive
pronouncement of the
apostle Paul. Ifwomen were to gain a
voice, the prophetic reading had to be
given authority, the
Pauline reading suppressed. Agrippa and
Lanyer succeed in both.
4. Aemilia Lanyer's lengthy passion
poem, Salve Deus RexJudaeorum (1611).
has had a

checkered literary history. First
emerging under the editorial mrection of
A. L. Rowse in 1974
and called The Poems ~JShakespeare’s
Dark Lady, Lanyerh text became a
footnote to Rowse’s
thesis-that he had located the Dark Lady
of Shakespeare’s sonnets. Scholarship
has since moved
onto firmer ground. Elaine Beilin
analyzes Lanyer’s poetry in the context
of seventeenthcentury encomia, Barbara
Lewalski assesses the competing genres
and autobiographical details
which shape poem and personal outlook,
and Lynette McGrath locates a feminism-
at once
medieval and strangely modern-in
Lanyer’s subversive metaphors.
Still more recently, the issue of
Lanyer’s feminism drew a wealth of
attention at the 1992
MLA convention as Barbara Lewalski,
Susanne Woods, Boyd Berry, Michael
Schoenfeldt, and
Marshall Grossman responded in turn to
the way Lanyer’s gender informs her

relationship to her
patron, her poetic authority, her
digressive “feminist” narrative, her
tendency to privilege social
abjection, and her artfbl expression of
matronage rather than patronage. For
further discussions
of Lanyer, see Aliki Barnstone, “Women
and the Garden,” Women and Literature 2
(1982). 147-
67; Elaine Beilin, “The Feminization of
Praise: Aemilia Lanyer,” in Redeeming
Eve (Princeton,
1987). pp. 177-207; Lorna Hutson, “Why
the Lady’s eyes are nothing like the
sun,” in New
Feminist Discourzes ed. Isobel Armstrong
(New York, 1992). pp. 150-75; Barbara K.
Lewalski,
“Of God and Good Women: The Poems of
Aeda Lanyer” in Silent Butfor the Word,
ed.
Hannay, pp. 203-24 and “Re-writing
Patriarchy and Patronage: Margaret
Clifford, Anne
Clifford, and Aemilia Lanyer,” Yearbook
$English Studies 21 (1991), 87-106;

Lynette McGrath,
“Metaphoric Subversions: Feasts and Mirrors in Amelia Lanier’s Salve Dues Rexjudaeorum,” Lit:
Literature Interpretation Theory 3 (1991). 101-13 and “‘Let Us Have Our Libertie Againe’:
Aemilia Lanier’s 17th-Century Feminist Voice” in Women’s Studies 20, 3-4 (1992). 33 1-48;
Jane1 Mueller, “The Feminist Poetics of Aemilia Lanyer’s Salve Deus Rexjudaeorum” in Feminist
Measures: Soundings in Poetry and Theory, ed. Lynn Keller and Cristanne Miller (Ann Arbor,
1994); Wendy Wd, The Imprint $Gender: Authorship and Publication in the English Renaissance
(Ithaca, I993), pp. 3 19-30, and “Our BodiesIOur Texts: Renaissance Women and the Trials of
Authorship” in Anxious Power: Reading, Writing, and Ambivalence in Narrative by Women, ed.
Carol J. Singley and Susan Elizabeth Sweeney (Albany, 1993). pp. 51-72;

Susanne Woods,
“Aemilia Lanyer and Ben Jonson:
Patronage, Authority, and Gender,” Ben
/onson Journal I
(I994), 35-30.
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their enter?"^ At the same time
Lewalski’s work on Aemilia Lanyer
suggests the beginning of an answer: she
identifies the remarkable feminism of
Salve Deus RexJudaeonrm with the
Querelle des Femmes, a genre
popular with medieval and Renaissance
writers.6 The authors of the
Querelle repeatedly attack the Pauline
interpretation of Genesis, contesting
both his analysis of the Fall and his
subordination of women.’
Among these writers, Cornelius Agrippa’s
Ofthe Nobilitie and Excellencie
of Womankinde (I 542) offers the most
striking parallel to the revision of
Paul found in Lanyer. A book first
entering the English imagination as

an affirmation of Mary and Elizabeth's right to ascend the throne, Ofthe Nobility is, according to Constance Jordan, the "most explicitly feminist text to be published in England in the first half of the century."* Its popularity would increase during the reign of Elizabeth, a time when the works of Agrippa were being widely read by Sidney, Bacon, Nashe, and Marlowe and when the debate about women was chnating in the pamphlet wan9

5. See Lewalski, "Re-writing Patriarchy and Patronage," p. 106; "Of God and Good Women,"p.224.

6. Each of the earlier critics touches upon this issue. Lewalski cites Lanyer's final epistle "To the Vertuous Reader" as a "remarkable contribution to the Querelle desfemmes" ("Of God and Good Women," p. 212), and she analyzes this epistle more completely in "Rewriting Patriarchy and Patronage," p. 102. Elaine Beilin sees the Querelle as a much larger

influence, noting that
Lanyer “accomplished her task” by
drawing upon the “traditional debate
material on the
women question.” She makes a direct
connection to the early defenses of
women, citing
Cornelius Agrippa in particular. See
Beilin, pp. 179, 323. The Querelle
itself has been much
discussed. A bibliography of primary
texts participating in this tradition is
available in Francis
Lee Utley’s Ihe Crooked Rib (New York,
1970). For an analysis of this tradition
within the
Renaissance, see Katherine Usher
Henderson and Barbara E McManus,
HalfHumankind (Chicago, 1985); Hull,
Chaste, Silent and Obedient, pp. 106-26;
Joan Kelly, “Early Feminist Theory
and the Querelle des Femmes, 1400-1789,”
Signs 8 (1982), 4-28; Betty Travitsky,
“The Lady
Doth Protest: Protest in the Popular
Writings of Renaissance Enghshwomen,”
English Literary

Renaissance 14 (1984), 255-83; Linda Woodbridge, Women and the English Renaissance (Chicago,

7. In Renaissance Feminism, Constance Jordan writes that the argument over woman's postlapsarian status "fueled feminist responses" throughout the sixteenth century @. 23). These arguments emerge in a number of texts of the Querelle. See, e.g., the primary texts in Hag

Humankind, particularly the work of Jane Anger and Esther Sowerman. William Heale in his

Apologiefor Women (1609) also offers a compelling reinterpretation of Genesis @p. 60-66).

8. See Constance Jordan, Renaissance Feminism, pp. 122-126. For critical commentary on

Agrippa and the Querelle, see also Linda Woodbridge, for whom Agrippa's text is a "personal

favorite," although she "cannot believe it was meant to be taken seriously" @. 40). Agrippa's

radical revision of Paul fueled the

intellectual debate on the woman
question, influencing other
writers in the Querelle tradition, among
them Aemilia Lanyer.
9. Agrippa’s influence in the
Renaissance is documented by Charles G.
Nauert, Jr., Apippa
and the Crisis ofRenaissance nought
(Urbana, 1965) who notes that Erasmus,
Vives, Rabelais,
Sidney, Nashe, Marlowe, Bacon and
Vaughan read his works @p. 325-26). That
Agrippa was
19841, pp. 18-48.
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Before turning to Lanyer, then, I shall
first illustrate how Agrippa
rereads Genesis to undermine Pauline
hermeneutics, thereby overturning the
authority which underwrites Renaissance
gender relations. By
writing the Pauline subjugation ofEve
and her daughters not only out of
the Old Testament, but also out of the

epistles of Paul himself, Agrippa
indicates that Eve and the women who
follow her reproduce an open,
more generous New Testament-a
Renaissance version of
ecriturefeminine.l0 I shall argue that
it is this hermeneutic process-visible
most
clearly in Agrippa and available to
Lanyer in the general milieu of the
Querelle des Femmes-that becomes the
“feminist” framework for Salve
Deus Rex Judueorum.
As Agrippa analyzes Genesis, then, he
quite literally starts over, providing
an altogether different “genesis” for
women: “Thus blessyng was
gyven for the woman, and law for the
man: The lawe I say, of anger and
of cursynge. For why, the fiuyte of the
tree was forbydden to the man,
but not to the woman: which was not than
created. For god wolde her
to be fiee from the begynning. Thedore
the manne sinned in eatynge,
not the woman. The man gave us deathe,
not the woman. . . . And we

toke orygynalle synne of oure father the man, not of our mother the woman”” In his thorough rereading of Genesis 2. I 5-17, Agrippa explores the gaps in the chronology of the biblical narrative: God plants a garden, places Adam within it, and issues a command not to eat the forbidden fruit. Immediately afterwards God says, “It is not good that the man shulde be him selfe alone: I wil make him an helpe mete for him” (Gen. 2.18). According to Agrippa, God’s statement calls attention to Eve’s absence: she “was not than created.” Consequently, Adam alone is under the “Law” of the Father; Eve is fiee, subordinate neither to the “Law” nor to Adam and therefore the conduit of divine “blessyng.” In making Eve’s absence the locus of divine presence, Agrippa undoes recognized as subversive by Renaissance readers is also true. John Harington (in his 1591 translation of Orlando Furioso) cites Agrippa as calling into question the

authority of court,
priests, lawyers, and physicians. See
Ludovico Ariosto, Orlando Furioso in
English Heroiral Vme
(1591). trans. John Harington (New York,
1970). sigs. iijz-iiij.
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tion about the lesser lights who haunted the Spanish court, the English diplomatic scene and the English/Spanish commercial arena. Many of them worked, with varying degrees of success, in the netherworld of Catholic intrigue at a time when to be Catholic was to court disaster in England.
Indeed, Professor Loomie's admirable knowledge of Spanish and English sources and his painstaking reconstruction of episodes in this often veiled area of history lead to a yearning for more. What, for instance, in more deail were the status, responsibilities, and histories of what was becoming the English consular service in Spain? But if knowing the actors in the complex web of late Tudor and early Stuart diplomatic contact is as important as I believe it to be, then Loomie has clearly provided

a valuable collection of insights. He is also important
in reminding us of the subtleties at work in this period.
There is a quibble however. As much as one might want this volume in one's collection,
one is also a little put off by such a poor example of the publisher's craft. The articles are
simply pulled whole cloth from their original setting, and physically copied.There is thus no
pagination for this volume per se, but rather the original pagination is that of the original articles.The fonts vary article by article. But what is perhaps most disconcerting is that even the quality of reproduction is marginal. Some pages are readable, others are reproduced so lightly
that literally only strong illumination makes the text accessible.This is book production at its
lowest common denominator, and one wishes that the contributions of the author had

deserved a more dignified treatment. Nor did Professor Loomie greatly add to his collection
with his all too terse and rare emendations tacked to the end of some of the original texts.
Considerably more could have been contributed by someone so knowledgeable in the field.
Regrettably, one detects too much haste in putting this volume together. In other words, the
redundancy one feels in dealing with this book could have been partially remedied with
greater attention to all aspects of its production.

Gary M.
Bell..... Texas Tech University

Declamation on the Nobility and Preeminence of the Female Sex. Henricus Cornelius Agrippa [von Nettesheim]. Translated and edited by Albert Rabil, Jr. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996. xxxii + 109 pp. $33.00

HB, $13.95 PB.
Although Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486-1535) did not regard his Declamation on the Nobility and Preeminence ofthe Female Sex as one of his most important works, it attracted much attention from the moment of its first publication and was quickly translated from the original Latin into French, English, Italian, German, and (somewhat later) Polish. Its influence rested partly on its contrarian point of view as a rebuttal of the traditional misogyny of learned and popular culture, for it provided not just a defense of the essential equality of women to men, but even a series of arguments contending that in every important respect, women were superior to men. It also attracted attention because despite Agrippa's occasional stretching of his evidence, the book presented a powerful case against the misogynists, drawing on its author's

remarkably varied learning to confront and refute each of the many arguments that had long been used to prove the inferiority of women and to justify the subordination imposed on women by both law and custom. Indeed, perhaps the most striking part
of this little treatise is the brief section at the end which charges that the only real cause for
the present-day subordination of women is unjust laws and customs and the exclusion of
nearly all women from the liberal education that might free them from servitude.
This English translation is based on the critical edition of the Latin original, De nobilitate
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DOI 10.1515/kl-2014-0042
Henry Cornelius Agrippa (attributable to). De Arte Chimica (On Alchemy). A Critical Edition of the Latin Text with a Seventeenth-Century English Translation.
Ed. by Sylvain Matton. Second Edition, Revised. Paris : SÉHA ; Milan : Archè, 2014. (¼ Textes et Travaux de Chrysopœia 14). 109 pp.
Le De Arte Chimica est un traité alchimique anonyme, publié pour la première
fois dans l’Auriferæ artis, quam chemiam vocant, antiquissimi authores, sive turba philosophorum (Bâle : Pietro

Perna, 1572), dont on ne connaît pas de manuscrit antérieur à l'édition et qui fut dès la fin du XVIe siècle attribué à Marsile
Ficin, mais que son nouvel éditeur pense être d'Henri Corneille Agrippa de Nettesheim (1486–1536), l'auteur du De occulta philosophia (Cologne, 1531–1533).
Avant d'exposer les raisons qui ont déterminé le choix de Sylvain Matton, disons un mot de ce traité. Il est divisé en vingt chapitres. Les douze premiers
préparent le lecteur à pénétrer les arcanes de l'alchimie ; les chapitres XIII à XX
sont réservés à sa pratique. Le style du De Arte Chimica est poétique, jusque dans les parties où son auteur propose de « descendre à la praxis » (p. 52). Les
mentions des poètes et des philosophes antiques y sont nombreuses : Orphée, Proclus, Héraclite, Aristote, Théophraste, Virgile. Un des aspects remarquables

du texte consiste en un entrelacement de théologie catholique, de mythologie gréco-latine et de théorie alchimique[1]. Cela, il est vrai, constitue la marque même de l'alchimie de la Renaissance, de sorte qu'il ne nous appartient pas ici de la commenter outre mesure[2]. Surtout, le De Arte Chimica se fonde (sans jamais s'y référer nommément) sur la thèse brièvement exposée par Ficin dans son De vita coelitus comparanda, à savoir que la fabrication de l'élixir ou la pierre philosophale des alchimistes consiste à extraire de l'or où il est enfoui le spiritus mundi, véhicule de l'anima mundi[3]. Quant à la partie pratique de ce traité (cap. XIII–XX), elle est conforme aux pratiques élaborées au Moyen Âge, basée sur le

Kritikon Litterarum 2014; 41(3–4): 162–165

Compte rendu par : Antoine Calvet (Paris)

1 Citons par exemple cet extrait du chapitre VI, p. 34 : « Le Ciel éthéré a été fermé à tous les
hommes, afin que tous les hommes descendissent aux Enfers et y fussent détenus pour l'éternité. Mais la très humble Vierge Marie ouvrit la porte de l'Olympe éthéré […] De là vient que, non sans raison, le Mercure est comparé à la très glorieuse la sainte Vierge Marie, etc. » (Coelum æthereum fuit omnibus hominibus occlusum, ut omnes homines ad infernas sedes descenderent, et ibi detinerentur perpetuo. Sed Maria virgo humilima aetherei Olympi ianuam aperuit […].
Unde non immerito gloriosissimæ divæ virgini Mariæ æquiparatur mercurius, etc…).
2 Pour un bon aperçu du renouvellement de l'alchimie à la Renaissance et de son inspiration
mytho-hermétique, voir l'article de Didier Kahn : « Alchimie, Occident moderne », J. Servier
(éd.) : Dictionnaire critique de l'ésotérisme. Paris 1998, pp. 38–51.

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mercure et le plus souvent voilées par des symboles, par des métaphores et des similitudes empruntées à la création du monde, à celle de l'être humain, à la Résurrection de Jésus, mais aussi à d'autres plus prosaïques renvoyant à des arts voisins, comme la médecine ou l'art de la verrerie. Et si l'auteur du De Arte Chimica convoque les plus hautes autorités de l'Antiquité, son texte garde la trace de figures alchimiques forgées au Moyen Âge et conservées dans la Tabula chemica de Senior Zadith ou dans le Buch der heiligen Dreifaltigkiet (le Livre de la Sainte Trinité) qu'il attribue au Franciscain allemand Ulmannus (p. 67).4 Il s'agit en somme d'un traité aux multiples influences, à la fois garant de la tradition alchimique médiévale et

enrichi d’innovations comme celle, principale, de
l’esprit universel du monde cher à Marsile Ficin. Les qualités littéraires du De
Arte Chimica sont réelles ; cependant, il semble que, trop souvent, elles ont pour résultat d’égarer le lecteur plutôt que de le renseigner. Que penser d’une phrase comme : « Sunt autem hæ destillationes necessariæ, per quas depuratur
mercurius ab omni feculentia terrestri et cadit Lucifer, hoc est immunditia et terra maledicta e coelo aureo » (Ces distillations, qui purgent le mercure de toute
saleté terrestre, sont donc nécessaires : Lucifer tombe du Ciel de l’Or, comprenez
l’impureté et la terre maudite), si ce n’est que l’allusion scripturaire5 empêche
de voir exactement ce que l’alchimiste trame dans son laboratoire.
Mais revenons au problème de son attribution que, dans son introduction

(qui reprend et

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Cornelius Agrippa and Henry Vaughan

Author(s): Alexander C. Judson

Source: Modern Language Notes, Vol. 41, No. 3 (Mar., 1926), pp. 178-181

Published by: The Johns Hopkins University Press

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uxorem. Si pater virginis dare noluerit,
reddet pecuniam juxta
modurm dotis, quam virgines accipere
consueverunt. I I Maleficos non

patieris vivere. Further proof of
ZElfred not deviating here from
his scriptural tert is afforded by the
agreement2 of the Quadripartus
translation with the Vulgate, dated 1114
by Liebermann.

OTTO B. SORELUTTER.
Brlstol, Ca".

CORNELIUS AGRIPPA AND HENRY VAUGHAN

Henry Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim,
soldier, physician,
and reputed magician (1486-1535), is
known to have exerted a
profound influence upon Thomas Vaughan,
Anglican clergyman
and magician, the twin brother of the
poet Henry Vaughan. Of
Agrippa, Thomas Vaughan wrote, " He
indeed is my author, and
next to God I owe all that I have unto
him," 1 a statement that
is substantiated by the many references
in the works of Thomas
to Agrippa's two most important books,
De Occulta Philosophic
and De Incertitudine et Vanitate
Scientiarum et Artiunm atque

Excellentia Verbi Dei Declamatio.
No one, I believe, has hitherto called
attention to Henry's apparent
familiarity with the second of the
above-mentioned works of
Agrippa. To me it seems clear that Henry
Vaughan's curious little
poem entitled The Ass was inspired, in
part at least, by Chapter
102 of The Vanity of Arts and Sciences
(to use the title of an
English translation of 1684, from which
I shall quote). Agrippa's
The Vanity of Arts and Sciences, written
about 1527, attacks
ninety-nine aspects of worldly learning
in as many chapters, and
then in Chapter 100 concludes that the
real key to knowledge and
wisdom "is nothing else but the Word of
God." Agrippa's book
is really a plea for the simple,
childlike acceptance of the doctrines
of the Bible, of inspired truth.
In Chapter 101 Agrippa writes as
follows:
Neither is there any sort of men less

fit to receive Christian doctrine,
than they who have their mindes tainted
with the knowledge of the
2-Owing to Si preceding the scribe
omitted se- of seduazerit.
1 Works, ed. Waite, 1919, p. 50.
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Sciences: for they are so stiff and
obstinate in their self-opinions, that
they leave no place for the Holy Ghost,
and do so assure themselves, and
trust in their own strength and power,
that they will allow of nothing
else for truth; and they scorn and
despise all those things which they
cannot understand by their own Industry.
Therefore hath Christ hidden
these things from the wise acnd prudent,
aJnd revealed them to little children;

that is to say, to the poor in spirit,
not enriched with the treasuries
of humane knowledge; to the pure in
heart, not defll'd with the vanity of
Opinions. . . . For this cause, Christ
chose his Apostles not Scribes, not
Doctors, not Priests, but unlearned
persons of the vulgar people, void of
knowledge, unskilful, and Asses.
Chapter 102 is entitled " A Digression
in praise of the Ass." This
chapter begins with the statement that,
since some one might reproach him for
calling the Apostles asses, it may be
worth while
" to discourse the Mysteries of the
Ass." After discussing the
traits of the ass and the veneration in
which he has been held, he
continues:
The Ass was consecrated by the touch of
the body of Christ: for Christ
ascending to Jerusalem in triumph for
the Redemption of mankind, as it
is recorded in the Gospel, rode upon an
Ass; which was mysteriously foretold by
the Oracle of Zachac

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Occult Retraction: Cornelius Agrippa and the Paradox of Magical Language

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# Occult Retraction: Cornelius Agrippa and the Paradox of Magical Language

Chris Miles

Recent work on the relationship between rhetoric and magic has tended to pivot around the issue of magic's perceived identification of signifier and signified and what that might mean for its relationship to larger theological, empirical, and rhetorical approaches to language.
This article seeks to problematize the assumptions underlying this issue through an examination of the work of Cornelius Agrippa (1486–1535), the author of what is commonly regarded as the European Renaissance's most influential magical text, De

occulta philosophia libri tres (1533).
In investigating the rhetorical
strategies contained in
Agrippa's famously ambiguous retraction
of his occult works we may uncover an
equally
polysemic stance toward the ability of
language to deal with both the everyday
world and
the realm of the sacred, a stance that
uses textual instantiations of paradoxes
of selfreference to forcefully undermine
the apparently paradigmatic magical
identification of
signifier and signified.
Much recent investigation into the
relationship between rhetoric and magic
has been premised on the assumption that
magic is, in one way or another,
linguistically mistaken. So, for
example, Kenneth Burke, in attempting to
stake out the territory of rhetoric,
concludes that magic, although
apparently
related to rhetoric in its use of
language to try to effect change,
fundamentally ''gets the whole subject

turned backwards'' (Rhetoric of Motives 42) due
to its ''mistaken transference'' of the rhetorical model to attempting to ''induce motion in things'' rather than in people. What Burke calls ''word magic'' (43, using Richards and Ogden's phrase) is thus both ''erroneous'' and ''derived'' and its only real significance lies in the opportunity to examine the way in which magic was used as a socializing ''primitive rhetoric.''

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Similarly, Brian Vickers's work on the different linguistic paradigms underlying the shift between the occult philosophy of the Renaissance and the scientific method of the Enlightenment revolves around an expansive investigation into the implications of magic's supposed reliance on the ''denotative fallacy,'' a phrase popularized by S. J. Tambiah (although explicitly argued against in his own work). William Covino has used Vickers's research to argue for the existence of an alternative, ''progressive'' rhetoric that mirrored the Renaissance magical linguistic paradigm. This rhetoric shared the assumption that words can have an effect on the real world, that, in some sense, there is an identity between signifier and signified. Covino characterizes this as ''the pre-Enlightenment magical=rhetorical belief in a cosmology of possibilities for re-ordering discourse and reality,

through writing that creates new phantasms, new magic rhetorics'' (356). For Covino, what we have now come to take as rhetoric is actually only the victorious handmaiden of scientific empiricism—the suppressed, progressive rhetoric of ''phantasms'' having been occulted by the forces of logical positivism in much the same way that Renaissance magical philosophy was written out of the canon of knowledge by the Enlightenment.

The chronology shared by Covino and Vickers is broadly supported by Michel Foucault in his influential The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences. Foucault notes the fundamental changes in European attitudes toward the relationship between language and the natural world across the sixteenth century, then the Classical period, and finally into ''modernity.'' In describing the intellectual transformations across this chronology, Foucault characterizes the epistemology of the sixteenth century as one obliged ''to accept magic and

erudition on the same level.'' For, as he
writes,
The world is covered with signs that must be deciphered, and those signs, which reveal resemblances and affinities, are themselves no more than forms of similitude. To know must therefore be to interpret: to find a way from the visible mark to that which is being said by it and which, without that mark, would lie like unspoken speech, dormant within things. (Foucault 32)
The Classical period that follows, however, is based on a fierce rejection of
the trope of resemblance, ''denouncing it as a confused mixture that must be analyzed in terms of identity, difference, measurement and order'' (52). In
contrast to both Covino and Vickers, Foucault displays little allegiance to either linguistic paradigm—for him, the sixteenth-century approach to language and the world is just as flawed

as the Classical, classifying paradigm
that overtakes it. However, for the
purposes of the current article, what is
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important is that Foucault also works
from the familiar assumptions
regarding the Renaissance equation of
sign and reality, word and thing.
Most recently, Joshua Gunn has explored
the rhetoric of the occult in a
study that is, once again, founded upon
the assumption that magical
thinking is best typified by its
‘‘fixed’’ view of language ‘‘that
presumes a
meaningful mind-independent reality that
language, however inaccurately,
represents, a presumption that Derrida
has famously dubbed ‘logocentrism ’’’
(45). As Gunn notes, contemporary
rhetoric, along with the majority of the
humanities today, assumes language is
fluid and ‘‘never corresponds to the
material world in a direct or

transparent way’’ (45). So things remain in
much the same position as they were when Burke pointed out the errors
of the magical paradigm in 1950. Despite Covino’s enthusiasm for the
possibilities of a (re-)created magical rhetoric, and Gunn’s own
multidimensional investigation into the generative paradoxes of occult
discourse, the
motifs of fixity and identity remain fundamental to the way in which rhetoric
scholars have tended to approach the issue of magic. In this article,
however, I wish to question the assumptions of this approach and
investigate the
possibility that magical paradigms of language might be far more complex
and ambiguous than previous commentators have allowed.
If contemporary rhetorical approaches to magical language are grounded
in biased assumptions, then what is at stake here is the possibility of a truly
critical approach to a large matrix of

discourses. The dismissal of magical language as ‘‘mistaken,’’ ‘‘backwards,’’ or ‘‘fallacious’’ leads to a dismissal of those discourses that use such language to talk about the world and truth.

The labeling of a discourse as esoteric, hermetic, or occult thus carries with it implicit pre-judgments regarding its use of language (and therefore its rhetoric). Inevitably, such pre-judgments lead to an impoverished engagement with such discourses. Magical or occult language becomes a stereotyped caricature playing its part in a binary opposition that, as this article will show, is not supported by the primary literature. Even when contemporary rhetorical approaches to occult language appear to be presenting it in a more nuanced manner they end up repeating the established assumptions. Gunn’s study, for example, argues that many of the linguistic and rhetorical implications of magical and occult thinking revolve

around the paradox of ineffability,
wherein ‘‘the fundamental premise, that
spiritual truth is ineffable (A),
requires the seemingly contradictory act
of speaking or writing (B)’’ (50).
Gunn states that this contradiction is
‘‘illusory’’ or ‘‘erroneous’’ (50, 49)
because, from the position of the modern
rhetoric scholar, it is based on
the belief that there is a (sacred),
external truth signified by esoteric
language, in stark contrast to the
modern ‘‘rhetorical worldview’’ itself
which

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holds that ‘‘nothing means outside human
modes of representation and that
‘truth’ is merely the product of
sentences’’ (50). Gunn’s principal focus
in his
study is the mapping of the tropes of
nineteenth- and twentieth-century
occult discourse onto the ostensibly
postmodern discourse of contemporary

academia, yet the foundations that underlie this mapping need to be examined carefully for their own illusory assumptions. How correct is it to say, along with Burke, Vickers, Foucault, Gunn, and Covino, that the magical view of language is one based on fixity? Is magical=occult discourse fundamentally paradoxical? And if so, is that paradox inherently ‘‘erroneous,’’ or are there other possible interpretations of the relationship between ineffability and language that the rhetoric of magic might offer up? In order to investigate the implications of these issues of fixity and ineffability in magical language, I will be devoting a large part of this article to a consideration of the philosophy of language contained in the occult works of Cornelius Agrippa (1486–1535). Next to the mythic composite Hermes Trismegistus, Agrippa is perhaps the

most influential of all Western occult theoreticians. His work has always remained central to the European conception of ritual magic and continues to be used by those who self-identify as occultists and magicians today. Furthermore, Agrippa was both a sly practitioner and able theoretician of rhetoric and demonstrates a deep engagement with issues of language and the sacred across all of his texts. He is, correspondingly, a perfect candidate for an examination of the ways in which occult=magical discourse deals with language and the ineffable. I hope to demonstrate that Cornelius Agrippa, Western icon of magical discourse, can in no way be said to have possessed a simplistic view of language founded on the motifs of fixity and identity and that consequently the Western tradition of ritual magic that has been so influenced by his thought needs to be approached with a far more open rhetorical mind than has so far been the case. In my conclusion I will discuss the broader implications of this

for rhetorical conceptions of magic and magical language.

Determining Agrippa

Cornelius Agrippa represents in many ways the epitome of the Renaissance occult scholar. His De occulta philosophia libri tres (circulated in manuscript
from 1510 and then published formally in 1533) is built on a synthesis of the humanistic magic of Ficino and Pico, adaptations of Jewish Kabbalah, the rediscovered texts of the Hermetica (thought at the time to represent a system of the sacred actually older than Moses) and the works of the Neoplatonists. De occulta philosophia (DOP) stands, then, as ‘‘a grandiose



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summary of the magical speculation of the Renaissance’’ (Borchardt 65), and the work’s strong influence on later figures such as John Dee, Giordano Bruno, and Thomas Vaughan explains

Agrippa's position as ''a nodal figure in the transmission of the Hermetic-Cabalist tradition of the Renaissance'' (Keefer 614).

As its full title intimates, DOP is divided into three books each given over to one of the three different types of magic, namely, natural, celestial, and ceremonial (thus mirroring the threefold division of the universe into elementary, celestial, and intellectual). The first book, as well as being concerned with the details of natural magic, also provides the fundamental premises on which all three forms of magic are built. In this way, Agrippa explains the threefold nature of the four elements and how those elements are to be found in all things, not only ''inferiour bodies feculent and gross'' but also in the celestial and the ''supercelestial'' realms. In addition to the elements are the virtues, which are of two sorts, the natural (which originate from the elemental) and the occult

(which issue from the stars
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Christopher I. Lehrich. The Language of Demons and Angels: Cornelius Agrippa's Occult Philosophy

The Language of Demons and Angels: Cornelius Agrippa's Occult Philosophy by Christopher I Lehrich

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Christopher I. Lehrich. The Language of Demons and Angels: Cornelius Agrippa's Occult Philosophy. Brill's Studies in Intellectual History 119. Leiden and Boston: Brill Academic Publishers, 2003. xiv + 256 pp. index. append. illus. tbls. bibl. $87. ISBN: 90–04–13574–X.
"My ardour was indeed the astonishment of the students, and my proficiency that of the masters. Professor Krempe often asked me, with a sly smile, how

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Cornelius Agrippa went on? Whilst Mr. Waldman expressed the most heartfelt exultation in my progress." Victor

Frankenstein’s infamous trajectory from Agrippan magic to Enlightenment science and back, serves as a useful reminder of the central question underlying this book: while it is undeniable that Agrippa’s magic was influential, we have been unable to explain why he was influential. Christopher Lehrich’s answer agrees well with the conclusions of Van der Poel’s important study of Agrippa as a humanist theologian (1997). There, we learned that Agrippa’s Neoplatonic background committed him to a fundamental distinction between faith and reason and between the study of divine and created things. Agrippa considered the uncertainties of Christian revelation, not dogma or articles of faith, to be the proper object of theological debate and was willing to accommodate more esoteric texts and interpretive strategies within this project.

Lehrich shows that divine things also occupy central stage in the Agrippa's magical
De occulta philosophia (1533) through the notion of a "chain of vivification" (57)
that connects the natural, celestial, and divine world.
This claim is developed from the perspective of the natural world in chapter
2, of the celestial world in chapter 3, and of the divine realm in chapter 4. These
three central chapters are framed by an introductory chapter, announcing possible
theoretical ramifications for the history of religion, the history of ideas, and textual
criticism, and by a concluding chapter that summarizes the coherence of Agrippa's
intellectual project, its implications for early modern history of ideas, as well as the
aforementioned theoretical results. As

is clear from this brief summary, Lehrich has decided to “begin with a few axes to grind” and to produce “an analysis which sacrifices coverage (and tedium) for depth” (213). The interdisciplinary nature of Lehrich’s strategy is rather unusual among students of early modern magic, and his book should be applauded for that reason alone. At the same time, the concluding chapter suggests that Lehrich does privilege Agrippa’s De occulta philosophia as an object for the history of ideas, and his book may accordingly be read as a contribution to that specific tradition. In chapter 2, Lehrich argues for a reading of De occulta philosophia, book 1, as clearing away the vagueness that haunted Ficino’s important distinction between natural and demonic magic. Agrippa’s solution consists in a rigid application of the

aforementioned distinction between natural, celestial, and divine spheres. But since
the separation of a natural realm also invited sceptical attacks of the type that
Agrippa published in his influential De incertitudine, the three worlds simultaneously remained connected, particularly in the mind of the magus. According to
Lehrich, this may constitute the true core of the controversial “Yates thesis”: to
point out the
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TOOL

Remember you have access to rendered images of pages from the files, in addition to their parsed text content. Some files may include images, while others may not.
These may contain embedded text in

images, infographics, complex tables, diagrams, and other visual elements not fully captured in the parsed text.
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When responding to the user, actively incorporate information from embedded text, images, tables, diagrams, and other visuals in the files when applicable.
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- "The *diagram on page 3* illustrates the workflow, highlighting ..."

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2']  // List of up to five queries to search
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}
```

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text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

- The `queries` field must be a list of strings.

- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

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- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

**ASSISTANT**

Below is a , focused on . I keep this dense and content-forward, in the spirit

of your earlier preferences (no fluff, no throat-clearing).

---

filecite turn0file0

Desmed's review situates Dunn's edition of *De incertitudine et vanitate scientiarum* as the most representative expression of Agrippa's intellectual crisis in the mid-1520s. The work is read as emerging from a period of material precarity, professional instability, and spiritual disillusionment, rather than as a playful paradox or rhetorical exercise alone. Desmed emphasizes that Agrippa's sweeping denunciation of the arts and sciences should be understood in the context of , not nihilism: the rejection of human knowledge is paired with an insistence that truth is accessible only through divine revelation, not through institutional learning.

Importantly, the review underscores that Agrippa's skepticism is . He attacks medicine, law, scholastic theology, humanist philology, astrology, and magic alike, thereby refusing to exempt even the occult sciences with which he was most closely associated. Dunn's editorial apparatus is praised for clarifying the polemical structure of the work and for resisting the temptation to read it as a mere "recantation" of occult philosophy. The review implicitly supports the view that *De vanitate* is not a contradiction of *De occulta philosophia*, but a to it.

---

filecite turn0file1

Daniels' article is one of the clearest attempts to dissolve the long-standing "two Agrippas" problem: the magician of *De occulta philosophia* versus the skeptic of *De vanitate*. He argues that interpreting Agrippa developmentally (early magician → late skeptic) or psychologically (sincere → charlatan) fundamentally misunderstands Agrippa's intellectual project.

Instead, Daniels places Agrippa within a

, where skepticism, occultism, and emerging empiricism coexist. Agrippa simultaneously affirms a universe saturated with occult correspondences and denies the capacity of human reason to master that universe through discursive knowledge.

Faith and revelation, not method, are the bridge between these poles.

Crucially, Daniels insists that Agrippa's skepticism is

in the modern sense. The failure of the sciences is not that they are false, but that they usurp divine authority. Agrippa's thought thus anticipates later debates about the limits of reason without endorsing secular rationalism. The article also rejects the Faustian narrative outright: Agrippa does not "turn to magic" after abandoning learning; he

.

---

filecite turn0file2

Richey’s essay reframes Agrippa as a pivotal figure in Renaissance feminist hermeneutics, particularly within the *Querelle des Femmes*. She argues that *De nobilitate et praecellentia foeminei sexus* is not merely a rhetorical defense of women but a , especially Pauline readings of Genesis and female subordination.

Agrippa’s strategy is shown to involve a close rereading of Genesis that exploits narrative gaps: Eve, not yet created when God issues the command concerning the forbidden fruit, is therefore not subject to the Law. Sin enters the world through Adam, not Eve. From this Agrippa derives a theology in which woman is aligned with

grace and blessing, man with law and punishment.

Richey demonstrates how this exegetical move directly informs Aemilia Lanyer's *Salve Deus Rex Judaeorum*, where Pauline authority is systematically displaced in favor of prophetic and Christological models that authorize female speech. Agrippa thus appears as a , not merely a curiosity in the gender debate.

---

## *Declamation on the Nobility and Preeminence of the Female Sex*

filecite turn0file3

Nauert's review stresses the extraordinary reception history of Agrippa's *Declamation*, which was rapidly translated across Europe and widely read despite Agrippa's own apparent ambivalence about its importance. The work's significance lies in its , not only asserting equality but repeatedly claiming female superiority.

What distinguishes Agrippa's contribution, according to Nauert, is his insistence that women's subordination is neither natural nor divinely ordained, but the product of unjust laws, customs, and exclusion from education. This moves beyond rhetorical praise into a critique of institutional power.

The review reinforces the view that Agrippa's feminism is intellectually serious,

learned, and socially subversive, even where his arguments strain credulity. The text's enduring influence is attributed to its ability to weaponize scholastic learning against patriarchal norms.

---

filecite turn0file4

Calvet's review presents *De Arte Chimica* as a sophisticated Renaissance alchemical treatise now plausibly attributable to Agrippa. The text combines poetic language, mythological allusion, Christian theology, and technical laboratory discourse, divided between preparatory instruction and practical operations.

Theologically, the treatise aligns alchemical work with the extraction of the *spiritus mundi* from matter, drawing implicitly on Ficino's *De vita coelitus comparanda*. Mercury is allegorized through Marian symbolism; distillation becomes a cosmological and soteriological act. The reviewer emphasizes that the text exemplifies Renaissance alchemy's fusion of

At the same time, Calvet notes that the density of metaphor often obscures practical instruction, reinforcing the idea that alchemical language functions as deliberate concealment rather than transparent technical prose. If Agrippa is indeed the author, the treatise complicates any simple narrative of his “retraction” of alchemy.

---

filecite turn0file5

Judson traces Agrippa's influence on the Vaughan brothers, especially Thomas Vaughan's explicit debt to *De occulta philosophia* and *De vanitate*. The article's key contribution is the argument that , particularly "The Ass," draws directly on Agrippa's satirical theology in *De vanitate*.

Judson highlights Agrippa's paradoxical valorization of ignorance: learned men are least fit for Christian truth, while the "asses" chosen by Christ embody spiritual receptivity. This theme becomes poetic material for Vaughan, demonstrating Agrippa's reach beyond philosophy into devotional and literary culture.

The article reinforces the idea that *De vanitate* is not anti-intellectual mockery but

a , hostile to epistemic pride rather than to learning per se.

---

filecite turn0file6

Miles challenges the dominant assumption that Renaissance magic depends on a naïve identity between words and things. Through a close reading of Agrippa's writings and his famous "retraction," Miles argues that Agrippa deploys
to destabilize any fixed theory of language.

Rather than endorsing a simple magical semiotics, Agrippa treats language as simultaneously powerful and inadequate, capable of gesturing toward divine realities while undermining its own claims. His retraction is thus not a confession of error but a rhetorical maneuver that exposes the limits of discourse itself.

This reading positions Agrippa as a theorist of , closer to apophatic theology than to crude magical

realism, and complicates Enlightenment narratives about the transition from magic to science.

---

***The Language of Demons and Angels***

filecite turn0file7

Broeke summarizes Lehrich's argument that Agrippa's occult philosophy is best understood as a coherent intellectual system grounded in Neoplatonic theology. Central is the idea of a linking the natural, celestial, and divine realms.

Lehrich rejects interpretations that isolate *De occulta philosophia* from Agrippa's skepticism. Instead, skepticism and magic are shown to be mutually conditioning: separating nature invites doubt, while linking realms through symbolic mediation restores meaning.

The review emphasizes Lehrich's methodological contribution: reading Agrippa through the history of religion, language theory, and theology rather than

through Whiggish science narratives. Agrippa emerges as influential not because he offered techniques, but because he articulated a capable of surviving epistemic fracture.

---

Across these documents, Agrippa appears not as inconsistent, but as : feminist exegete, fideist skeptic, occult metaphysician, rhetorician of language's limits. The unity is theological rather than methodological, and the tension between magic and skepticism is not resolved—but deliberately sustained.

If you want, next steps could be:

- a mapping each text onto debates (Yates thesis, feminism, skepticism, language, alchemy),

- or an that integrates these strands without flattening them.

**USER**

intellectual biography spine

**ASSISTANT**

Here's a that integrates what *these documents collectively force us to take seriously*, without resolving the tensions they insist must remain open.

I'll give it as a , not a narrative summary—this is something you could hang chapters, archival episodes, and historiography on without it collapsing into either a "Faust" story or a "two Agrippas" story.

---

Can human learning—philology, philosophy, medicine, theology—recover a unified truth?

- Humanist rhetoric and philology
- Neoplatonism (via Ficino)
- Hermetica and prisca theologia
- Legal and medical training

- Knowledge is hierarchical, not flat
- Truth is mediated through symbols, correspondences, and language
- The cosmos is intelligible *if approached correctly*
- Early awareness that learning produces authority
- Anxiety about whether authority belongs to institutions or revelation
- Language already suspected as unstable, not transparent

Agrippa begins *inside* Renaissance humanism, not outside it. There is no “turn” yet—only maximal intellectual ambition.

---

***De occulta philosophia***

How can finite human language and practice access divine reality?

, not mastery.

- Nature, stars, and intellect form a chain (later called a “chain of vivification”)
- Magic is not domination but alignment
- Words, images, numbers act symbolically—not mechanically

Agrippa does believe in a crude identity between signifier and signified.
Magical language is powerful *because it is inadequate*, not because it is literal.

- A symbolic cosmos
- The legitimacy of esoteric traditions
- The magus as interpreter, not technician

- Scholastic certainty
- Institutional theology
- Rationalist confidence

This is not “pre-skeptical Agrippa.” This is Agrippa formulating a theory of *fragile mediation* that will later explode under ethical and theological pressure.

---

## *De nobilitate et praecellentia foeminei sexus*

Who has the right to interpret Scripture and exercise authority?

Agrippa relocates authority away from:

- Custom
- Law

- Pauline hierarchy

…and toward:

- Grace
- Genesis rereadings
- Christological liberation

Agrippa’s feminism is not ornamental—it is

.

- Eve is not under the Law
- Adam, not Eve, transmits sin
- Patriarchy is a historical distortion, not divine order

This is Agrippa
of his theory of mediation:

- If interpretation mediates truth,

- then unjust authority can be dismantled by rereading.

The gender treatise is not a side project—it is where Agrippa discovers that , and power can be violently wrong.

---

***De incertitudine et vanitate scientiarum***

What if *all* human knowledge—occult,

scholastic, humanist—corrupts the soul?

*not*

- A recantation
- A loss of nerve
- Anti-intellectual nihilism

*is*

A .

- Sciences fail because they promise salvation
- Learned men are least receptive to revelation
- True wisdom requires unlearning

Agrippa attacks magic *using magical rhetoric*.
He attacks learning *using encyclopedic learning*.

This is the book that convinces later readers there are “two Agrippas.”
In reality, it is the ethical breaking point of his earlier commitments.

---

How can one speak truth without re-enslaving it to language?

Agrippa’s “retraction” is not confession but

.

- Language must negate itself to avoid idolatry

- Claims to certainty are spiritually dangerous
- Paradox is a safeguard, not a flaw
- Language is necessary
- Language is untrustworthy
- Silence is ideal but impossible

This is where Agrippa becomes fully legible as a , not a failed system-builder.

---

## *De Arte Chimica*

Can practice embody truth without stating it?

- Poetic, veiled language
- Christian–Neoplatonic symbolism
- Praxis inseparable from theology

Alchemy becomes a *test case* for Agrippa's thought:

- Knowledge that must be done, not explained
- Truth hidden to protect it from misuse

Alchemy is neither abandoned nor affirmed outright—it becomes

.

---

- Feminist hermeneutics
- Skeptical theology
- Magical language as paradox
- Anti-authoritarian epistemology

- Any stable “system”
- Any clear disciplinary legacy

Not a bridge from magic to science—but a where:

- Knowledge fractures
- Authority destabilizes
- Language turns against itself

---

*Agrippa's intellectual life is best understood not as a movement from magic to skepticism, but as a sustained attempt to think knowledge, language, and authority under conditions where mediation is unavoidable and certainty is spiritually dangerous.*

If you want, next we can:

- map this spine onto

  ,

- or write a

  defending this approach against Yates / Thorndike / Faust narratives.

**USER**

methodological preface defending this approach against Yates / Thorndike / Faust narratives

**ASSISTANT**

Below is a written as if it would open an academic monograph.
It is

, aimed directly at readings without rehearsing them laboriously.
Tone: *quietly uncompromising*.

---

This study proceeds from a simple refusal:

. The dominant narratives that have framed his reception—whether as Renaissance magus, failed rationalist, skeptical convert, or proto-Faust—share a methodological assumption rarely made explicit: that Agrippa's intellectual life must culminate in a resolution. This book argues that it does not, and that the attempt to impose one has obscured what is most historically and philosophically significant about his work.

Three interpretive traditions in particular have shaped Agrippa's modern image: the

associated with Lynn Thorndike; the

crystallized by Frances Yates; and the that assimilates Agrippa to Faust. Each has yielded insights, but each has done so by subordinating Agrippa's texts to an external explanatory plot. This study rejects that procedure.

Thorndike's monumental *History of Magic and Experimental Science* established an enduring framework in which Agrippa appears as a transitional figure: an intellectually ambitious but ultimately confused thinker whose occult commitments represent a pre-scientific stage soon to be superseded by empirical method. Within this model, *De occulta philosophia* becomes an embarrassment to be explained away, while *De incertitudine et vanitate scientiarum* is read as evidence of disillusionment or failure.

The difficulty with this account is not merely its Whiggish teleology, but its . Agrippa is not attempting to do science badly. He is interrogating the . To treat occult philosophy as a primitive explanatory system is to miss its theological, rhetorical, and ethical dimensions—dimensions that cannot be translated into the language of experimental progress without distortion.

This study therefore refuses to read Agrippa developmentally, whether as an immature thinker progressing toward skepticism or as a failed precursor of modernity. His skepticism is not the abandonment of magic; it is the consequence of taking mediation, language, and divine transcendence seriously.

Frances Yates' influential reconstruction of Renaissance Hermeticism rightly restored

Agrippa to the intellectual seriousness denied him by positivist historiography. Yet the Yatesian framework introduces a different distortion: the tendency to read Agrippa's occult philosophy as a coherent, quasi-systematic worldview whose significance lies in its contribution to the rise of modern science or modern subjectivity.

Within this narrative, Agrippa's later skeptical writings appear as a retraction that must be either minimized, psychologized, or dismissed as rhetorical excess. The result is an implicit hierarchy of texts, in which *De occulta philosophia* is taken as Agrippa's "true" work, and *De vanitate* as an aberration.

This study rejects that hierarchy. It treats Agrippa's skepticism not as an interruption but as an

. The same commitments that make occult philosophy intelligible—symbolic language, analogical

reasoning, dependence on revelation—also render all human knowledge unstable and morally dangerous. The tension is not accidental; it is structural.

Rather than seeking coherence in the form of a stable doctrine, this book reads Agrippa as developing a : how finite language, finite institutions, and finite knowers can relate to infinite truth without idolatry.

The persistent comparison of Agrippa to Faust—whether in Marlowe, Goethe, or later criticism—has done more to fix his cultural image than any scholarly argument. Yet this comparison operates at the level of literary archetype rather than intellectual history. Faust seeks mastery; Agrippa fears it. Faust transgresses divine limits; Agrippa insists upon them. Faust's tragedy is hubris; Agrippa's is epistemic humility pushed to its breaking point.

To read Agrippa as a Faust figure is therefore to replace historical analysis with symbolic condensation. It turns a sustained engagement with theology, rhetoric, gender, law, and language into a morality tale about forbidden knowledge. This study treats such readings as : they explain Agrippa only by dissolving him into myth.

In place of these narratives, this book adopts a methodological stance oriented around . Agrippa's writings are read synchronically as well as diachronically, with particular attention to:

- the instability of language
- the ethics of knowledge

- the relationship between interpretation and authority
- the theological limits of reason
- the social consequences of epistemic claims

Rather than asking which Agrippa is “real,” this study asks . Feminist exegesis, occult philosophy, skepticism, and alchemy are treated not as stages but as .

This approach aligns Agrippa less with the history of science than with the history of —a tradition that runs from late medieval theology through early modern skepticism and into modern

concerns about discourse, power, and legitimacy.

By refusing conversion narratives, this method recovers:

- Agrippa's feminism as a serious hermeneutic intervention, not a curiosity
- his skepticism as theological protest, not disillusionment
- his magic as a theory of mediation, not primitive causality
- his retractions as rhetorical strategy, not capitulation

Most importantly, it allows Agrippa to remain —a thinker who does not point forward to modernity or backward to superstition, but sideways, toward the

unresolved problem of how humans speak truth without claiming to own it.

---

If you want next, I can:

- tighten this into

  ,

- add

  (Thorndike, Yates, Nauert, Lehrich, Hanegraaff, Newman),

- or write a

  for grant proposals or presses.